

The 20-Minute Daily Drill Programme

Aaron Ellis · built from 81 measured takes, June–August 2026 · every drill here exists because a number says it should

Nothing in this programme is here because it is traditional, and nothing targets something you already do well. Your pitch centring measures at professional level and gets no minutes at all. The drills come from the elite-coaching synthesis in your knowledge base; the choice of which drills comes from your own measurements.

Where you actually are

Measure	You	Professional	Verdict
Clean note entries	23.7% (16th pct)	median 33.2%	worst gap
Entries scooped into	47.9% from −98.8¢	median 41.6%	rate is near normal
Entries overshot	29.3%	median 24.0%	the other half of the miss
Phrase endings that sag	51.5%	Farnham 28.6–29.7%	second worst
Drift inside a held note	39.8¢	Farnham 15.1–24.0¢	what listeners hear
Median phrase length	2.7 s	You're the Voice 5.57 s	half the length
Deviation from the note you land on	22.5¢	20–25¢	already reference level

Your landing is fine. Your approach is not. You arrive dead centre on the note — you just slide up into 47.9% of them from nearly a semitone below, and overshoot another 29.3%. Only **23.7%** start clean, against a professional median of 33.2%. You miss the centre in both directions.

For contrast: Farnham on Pressure Down scoops from −82.5¢ — barely shallower than you. He just does it **three times less often, and by choice.**

You live on your passaggio. Most-used note **E4**. Working tessitura **A3–F#4**. Passaggio estimates cluster **C#4–F4**. The note you sing more than any other is the note your voice changes gear on — which is why full nights tax you, and why passaggio work is maintenance rather than an extra.

The programme — 20 minutes, 5-6 days a week

The seventh day is not laziness. It is when the adaptation lands.

#	Block	Min	Moves this number
0	SOVT wake-up	3	prepares everything, costs nothing
1	Onset planting	5	clean 23.7% → 33%+
2	Sustain → messa di voce	3	drift 39.8¢ → under 25¢
3	Passaggio, vowels & range	4	strain at F4; M2 in songs
4	Twang	2	carrying power without volume
5	Song application	1	phrase 2.7 s → 4 s+
6	Cool-down	2	tomorrow's freshness

15-minute version: blocks 0, 1, 2 and 6. Never cut block 0, never cut the cool-down.

The Farinelli breath comes OFF the clock — that is a promotion. It is completely silent, so it costs your folds nothing, which means rationing it to one slot was the wrong call. Do it **three or four short goes a day**: driving, on the couch, before sleep, waiting for the kettle.

Inhale 4 — suspend 4 — exhale 4, six rounds, adding a count to the easiest phase each week. Then one steady hiss on “sss”, timed; **target 25 seconds** with no wobble and no collapse at the end.

The whole exercise is the suspension, and the classic error is doing it in the wrong place. The hold is your ribs staying wide — not your throat closing. Test: start a quiet hum straight out of the suspension. A click, a catch or a little push means you held it at the glottis.

The blocks

Block 0 — SOVT wake-up · 3 min

Always first. Always. Semi-occluded work gets the folds vibrating at a fraction of the collision force, so it prepares the instrument without spending it.

- **Water jar**, tube 2–4 cm under, gentle sirens low→high→low — 90 seconds.
- **Straw or lip-trill glides**, five slow passes across your comfortable range — 90 seconds.

Block 1 — Onset planting · 5 min · the biggest gap

1a. Three-onset contrast (2 min). One comfortable pitch, say D4. Sing “ah” three ways and feel the difference — breathy (“haaah”, air first), hard (a small glottal click), and balanced (air and tone together, no h, no click). Five rounds. You cannot fix an onset you cannot feel.

1b. Silent-target planting (2 min). Play a note. **Stop the sound.** Hear it in your head. Breathe. Land it — no slide, straight onto the centre. Hold two seconds. Ten different pitches.

1c. Deliberate contrast (1 min). One phrase, sung scooping on purpose, then clean. Alternate three times. Contrast is how ears learn — you cannot currently hear your own scoops because they are your normal.

See it, land it, stay on it. Scooping is what a voice does when it is searching for the note. Take away the search and you take away the scoop.

Block 2 — Sustain, then messa di voce · 3 min

2a. Straight tone against a drone (2 min). Play a drone — tuner app, keyboard, anything. Sustain against it: straight, no vibrato, no swell, 8–10 seconds. Five notes. Drift is nearly impossible to hear alone and instantly obvious against a reference pitch.

2b. Messa di voce (1 min). Same pitch, soft → full → soft on one breath. **Two notes only.** Better done twice properly than five times badly.

Steady first, shape second. If the straight tone is not solid, skip the messa di voce today — you would be practising drift with volume added on top. Pushing the crescendo is the trap, and under load your measured pattern is to default to power. **The swell has to be earned.**

Block 3 — Passaggio, vowels & range · 4 min

- **Straw/tube glides through C#4-F4** — slowly, listening for any audible gear change.
- **Descending 5-tone from above the passaggio** on “oo” or “ee”, coming down through C#4-F4. Descending brings M2 down and blends it.

Vowel modification (aggiustamento) — 90 seconds. Sing the same word up a scale through E4 and above, letting the vowel migrate as the pitch rises:

Vowel	As you climb, move it toward	Cue
“ee” /i/	more open	ee → ih
“oo” /u/	more open	oo → uh
“ah” /a/	rounder	ah → aw

The tell is unmistakable: the note suddenly rings and gets easier. If you are muscling something at F4, the vowel is the first thing to change — before the volume, before the support.

Range grows from coordination, not force. Extend at the top of a glide, never on a held note, a semitone at a time. A note you can only reach by pushing is not a range note, it is a risk.

Block 4 — Twang · 2 min · your alternative to volume

Slide on “**ng**” (the end of sing) across the mid-range, then open it into a bratty, slightly nasal “**nay-nay-nay**” on a 5-tone scale. Keep it **bright and buzzy, never loud**. The tell is a focused ring you can feel in the front of your face.

Read this the night before a competition round. Your measured failure mode under pressure — confirmed by two independent systems and by your own diagnosis of the semi-final you lost — is that you reach for **power**. Twang is the thing to reach for instead: louder in the frequencies a room actually hears, without being louder at the folds.

“One gear in reserve” tells you what not to do. **This is the thing to do.**

Block 5 — Song application · 1 min

One phrase. Not a whole song. Apply whatever today's focus was, then the phrase-length ladder — yours is **2.7 s** median, You're the Voice is **5.57 s**. Sing one long phrase on a single breath and add a beat when it is comfortable.

“Last word loud” — carry the intensity all the way to the final syllable instead of letting it trail. That is the sag, in one instruction.

Block 6 — Cool-down · 2 min

Gentle SOVT — hum or straw, quiet — then **descending glides only**, from comfortable down to the bottom, five or six passes. Nothing loud, nothing high. Two minutes returns the voice to neutral and reduces the fatigue you carry into tomorrow. **Do it after gigs too — especially after gigs.**

Two phases, and the second matters more than it looks

The blocks above are **blocked practice** — one coordination, repeated. That is the right way to acquire a skill and the wrong way to keep it under pressure. Motor-learning research is consistent and slightly counter-intuitive: **random and variable practice produce better retention and transfer, even though blocked practice looks better while you are doing it.** That distinction decides your December.

Phase 1 — blocked · now → mid-September

Day	Heavy block
Mon	Onsets (1)
Tue	Sustain / messa di voce (2)
Wed	Light voice day — SOVT, twang, cool-down only
Thu	Onsets (1)
Fri	Passaggio & vowels (3)
Sat	Song application (5), or a gig
Sun	Off, or recovery version

Phase 2 — variable · mid-September → the competition

Same minutes, same drills, deliberately disordered:

- **Shuffle the order.** Do not run 0→6. Mix the blocks so you never know what is next — that is the whole point.
- **Interleave instead of blocking.** Rather than five straight minutes of onsets: onsets → sustain → onsets → passaggio, a minute at a time.
- **Vary the context.** Standing. Moving. Holding a mic. At performance volume. In shoes you would gig in.
- **Grow song application** — it becomes the biggest block, run under performance conditions with the backing track.

Phase 2 will feel worse than Phase 1. That is the expected result, not a problem. If you do not know that in advance, you will assume you have gone backwards and revert to the version that felt better.

Microphone technique — Phase 2, and it is not optional

You have already lost one take to going too loud in a hot room. Concrete distances, from Shure's engineering guidance:

Line type	Distance from the mic
Quiet, intimate	1 inch or less
Normal	1.5 – 3 inches
Belting / money notes	6 inches to arm's length

Turn slightly **off-axis** on plosives and on your loudest high notes. Working the mic is the difference between a room hearing dynamics and a room hearing distortion — and it lets you sing the big note at a sane level.

The rules that override everything

- 1. Never train through hoarseness.** Mild post-load irritation that clears overnight is fatigue. Hoarseness still there after a full rest day is a stop sign.
- 2. Pain is always a stop.** Singing should feel free. It should never hurt.
- 3. Still hoarse a week later,** or top notes gone and not returning — that is a laryngologist, ideally one who scopes, not a wait-and-see.
- 4. Whisper is worse than quiet speech.** On a rest day, speak softly.
- 5. You cannot train two systems to failure at once.** You are mid rib-loading.
- 6. Fresh beats drilled,** especially inside nine weeks of a competition.

Recovery version (post-gig, tired, mildly irritated): block 0, the Farinelli breath, block 6. Roughly six minutes, almost no cost to the folds, and it keeps the streak without the risk. **Deload every fourth week** — halve everything. Adaptation lands during the easy week, not the hard one.

How you will know it is working

Do not judge this by feel. Record **one take of Pressure Down or Reasons a month**, same conditions, and read four numbers:

Number	Today	3-month target	Where
Clean entries	23.7% (16th pct)	33%+ (50th)	ENTRY ACCURACY
Phrase endings sagging	51.5%	under 35%	METRICS · breath
Intra-note drift	39.8¢	under 25¢	METRICS · intonation
Median phrase length	2.7 s	4 s+	METRICS · dynamics

Do not expect the overall /10 to move much, even if all four improve. Phrase control and breath support carry 0.10 each, and onsets are not scored at all. The point of this programme is to sound better to a room, not to move a number — and the blind listening test proved your ear registers these things even when the score does not.

The benchmark that should change the plan: no movement on a coordination after **three to four months** of consistent work means the approach is wrong, not that you need more of it. Change the drill or get a second opinion.

Sources — the gaps targeted here are measured from your own archive (81 active takes, rubric v5, calibration 1d3e2991f144). The drills chosen to close them come from “Inside the Elite Contemporary Vocal Lesson” in the vocal knowledge base. No number in this document was rounded toward the flattering side.